WEST BENGAL

The Case of the Missing Buses

By Arkamoy Datta Majumdar

tion areas of Kolkata, Bidhannagar, Howrah and Chandannagar, along with the adjacent parts of the North and South 25 Parganas, Hooghly, Nadia and Howrah districts. As the policy was implemented, about 4,000 buses had to go. To save the situation, 2,000 buses were inducted between 2009 and 2011. These very buses will have outlived their shelf life by 2024-end. "We will have around 3,000 buses plying in this large area. It's massively inadequate," says Rahul Chatterjee, general secretary of the All Bengal Bus Minibus Samannay Samiti, an apex body of transport operators.

Chatterjee claims that bus owners/ operators are unwilling to replace withdrawn buses as they incur huge losses due to the government not allowing them to hike passenger fares since 2018. "Consider how costly fuel is. On top of that we have to maintain the vehicles and pay staff. How can we operate without raising fares?" he asks.

As private buses were withdrawn, dependency on West Bengal Transport Corporation (WBTC)-run buses increased. Between 2014 and 2016, with financial impetus provided by the Centre's Jawaharlal Nehru National Urban Renewal Mission, some spanking new buses were added to the fleet. "With the new Volvo buses, it looked like a win-win situation," says a former WBTC official. However, the facelift couldn't offset the fast declining numbers as a whole.

According to WBTC sources, the problem also has to do with an acute shortage of manpower. The WBTC has a sanctioned strength of 837 drivers, but only 124 are permanent while others are engaged on a contractual basis. Overall, there is a vacancy of around 40 per cent for bus conductors and drivers. Result: WBTC buses often cannot complete the mandated two trips a day on a route.

State transport minister Snehasis Chakraborty, however, says that over 1,500 new buses have been registered in the past five years. "Around 700 WBTC buses run every day. Plus, 40,000-50,000 cabs have been registered in Kolkata in recent years. Commuters need not worry," he tells INDIA TODAY. The petition before the SC, says Chakraborty, will be based on certain facts. Firstly, the 2008 order was based on older BS I and II models. Currently, BS VI model buses are used, which have longer durability and are less polluting. Also, it will be argued that well-maintained buses don't need to be replaced every 15 years.



PRIVATE BUSES ARE NOT BEING REPLACED AS OWNERS ARE NOT ALLOWED TO RAISE FARES. AND WBTC HAS A MANPOWER SHORTAGE

Irrespective of the assurances, Kolkata streets have visibly fewer buses. For many, the switch to app-based cabs/ bikes isn't a viable economic transition. One only hopes the city's buses don't meet the fate of its trams, the last of which trundle along on a few remaining routes. ■